THE SOURCING PLAYBOOK

You make your money when you buy — not when you sell.

Where to find inventory that actually profits, the 30-second check that kills bad buys before you make them, what holds value and what to avoid, and a sourcing routine you can repeat every week.

Updated Nov 2026 Beginner → intermediate ~16 min read

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01

Your profit is set at the buy

New resellers obsess over selling — better photos, better listings, better prices. That stuff matters at the edges. But the truth the pros know is simpler: **the margin is locked in the moment you buy.** You cannot sell your way out of overpaying.

> **Discipline at the buy beats hustle at the sale. A great sourcer with mediocre listings still wins. A great seller who overpays loses.**

So this guide is mostly about one skill: knowing — before money leaves your hand — whether an item will actually make you money. Everything else is logistics.

02

The 30-second sourcing check

Run this on your phone, standing in the aisle, before every buy. If you can't answer all three, put it down.

1. **What did it actually SELL for?** Not the asking price — the *sold* price. On eBay, filter to "Sold items." On sneakers, check StockX/GOAT last sales. Asking prices are fantasy; sold prices are facts.
2. **How often does it sell?** Look at how many sold recently vs how many are listed. Ten sold this month and five listed = liquid. Two sold this year and 90 listed = you'll be holding it forever.
3. **After fees and my cost, do I keep enough?** Run the resale price through the break-even multiplier from Guide 01. If it doesn't clear your target profit, it's not a deal — no matter how "cheap" it feels.

The discipline: "it's only $5" is not a reason to buy. "It sells for $40, moves weekly, and I keep $25 after fees" is. Feelings lose money; comps make it.

03

Sell-through beats "it's worth a lot"

Sell-through rate = how many of a thing sold versus how many are listed, over a period. It's the single most underrated number in reselling, because it tells you whether your money comes *back*.

A quick way to eyeball it on eBay: compare the count of *sold* listings to *active* listings for the same item. Lots sold, few listed → high sell-through → cash moves fast. Few sold, tons listed → you're item #91 in line.

WHY IT MATTERS MORE THAN PRICE

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$30 profit every week ≫ $200 profit once a year
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Cash that moves compounds. A fast-selling $30 flip you can repeat 50 times a year makes far more than a prestigious $200 item gathering dust. Chase *velocity*, not just margin.

04

Where to source, ranked

No single source is "best" — they trade cash, effort, and margin. Start where your time and budget fit, then specialize.

SOURCE	BEST FOR	CASH	EFFORT	MARGIN
Thrift stores	Clothing, vintage, books, brand-name finds	Low	High	High
Garage & estate sales	Everything — tools, collectibles, electronics	Low	High	Very high
Retail clearance	New-in-box items at markdown (Target, Ross, TJ Maxx)	Med	Low	Medium
Outlet stores	New Nike/NB/designer → resell platforms	Med	Low	Medium
FB Marketplace / OfferUp	Underpriced local electronics, furniture, consoles	Varies	Med	High
Liquidation / pallets	Bulk volume, returns — advanced	High	High	Variable
Auctions / storage units	High-variance gambles — experienced only	High	High	Variable

Where to start with little cash: thrift stores and garage/estate sales. Low buy-in, highest margins, and you learn to spot value fast. The flashier sources (pallets, storage units) eat cash and punish beginners — grow into them.

05

What holds value — and what doesn't

Some things reliably resell; some are traps that feel like finds. General patterns — markets shift, so always comp.

✓ Tends to flip well

- **Sneakers** — Jordan, Nike SB, limited Dunks, New Balance
- **Durable brands** — Carhartt, Patagonia, The North Face, vintage denim
- **Lego** — retired sets climb hard
- **Trading cards & sealed games** — Pokémon, retro consoles
- **Power tools** — DeWalt, Milwaukee, Snap-on
- **Small appliances** — Dyson, KitchenAid, espresso machines
- **Vintage tees & band merch**, designer archive, hype drops

✕ Usually a trap

- **Fast fashion** — Shein, H&M, Forever 21: near-zero resale
- **No-name / unbranded** anything you can't comp
- **Heavily faked items** you can't authenticate
- **Bulky, low-value** goods — shipping eats you alive
- **Fast-depreciating tech** — last year's cheap phones/tablets
- **Saturated items** — 200 already listed, few selling
- **Damaged goods** you "can fix later" (you won't)

The through-line: brands with demand and scarcity hold value; generic, abundant, or fragile things don't. When in doubt, the sold-listings count tells you the truth.

06

The spot-math buy rule

You don't need a calculator in the aisle — you need a ceiling. Work backward from the realistic resale price (from your comps), then cap what you'll pay.

MOST YOU SHOULD PAY

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realistic resale × ( 1 - fee% ) - shipping - your target profit
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Fast rule of thumb for a healthy flip: **pay no more than a third to a half of what it realistically resells for.** A jacket that sells for $60 on a ~13% platform, $9 to ship, $25 target profit → pay at most about $18. Over that, walk away.

This is the same break-even math as Guide 01, just run in reverse — resale first, costs out, and whatever's left is your hard ceiling. Write your ceiling before you negotiate, and hold it.

07

Authentication & avoiding fakes

Sneakers, designer, trading cards, and electronics are flooded with convincing fakes. Selling one — even unknowingly — gets you banned and refunded. Protect yourself:

- **Learn one category deeply** before you spend real money in it. Know the tells: stitching, tags, box labels, weight, fonts.
- **Use authenticated platforms** (StockX, GOAT) for hype items — they verify before the buyer gets it. You pay more in fees for that protection; often worth it.
- **If you're not sure, it's a no.** A passed-up real item costs nothing. A fake costs your money, your account, and your rep.
- **Keep proof of purchase** for anything high-value — receipts settle disputes.

08

Timing & seasonality

The same item is worth different amounts in different months. Buy when nobody wants it, sell when everybody does.

- **Buy off-season, sell in-season.** Coats and boots: buy in spring, sell in fall. Grills and patio: buy in fall, sell in spring.
- **Holidays spike demand.** Toys, collectibles, and gifts peak Oct–Dec. Costumes spike before Halloween.
- **Hype drops have a clock.** Sneaker and streetwear resale is hottest right after a sold-out drop, then cools. Move fast.

- **Tax-refund season (Feb–Apr)** puts cash in buyers' pockets — big-ticket items move better.

09

Rookie mistakes that cost money

- **Buying off the asking price,** not the sold price. The #1 beginner mistake.
- **Emotional buys** — "this is so cool" is not "this will sell."
- **Ignoring fees and shipping** until the sale, then realizing you lost money.
- **Hoarding slow sellers** — cash tied up in dead inventory can't buy winners.
- **Going high-ticket with no cushion** — one $600 flip that won't sell can freeze your whole operation.
- **Not listing fast.** An item in a pile earns nothing. Source it, list it within 48 hours, log it.

10

A repeatable weekly routine

Winning resellers aren't lucky — they run a loop. Here's a simple one:

1. **Set a sourcing budget** you can afford to tie up — and stick to it.
2. **Source on a schedule** — pick your sources and go weekly, not randomly.
3. **Run the 30-second check on every item.** Comp, sell-through, margin. No comp, no buy.
4. **List within 48 hours** — and log every buy in the tracker so you always know your real numbers.
5. **Reinvest profit, not rent.** Roll winnings back into inventory; take out only what's yours to keep.

6 **Niche down** to what you know best — depth in one category beats dabbling in ten.

Every buy you log in Margin sharpens the next one: you'll see which categories, sources, and price points actually profit for *you* — and double down on them.

A note on expectations. Resale markets shift constantly — what flips well this year may cool next year, and prices vary by region and season. Everything here is general guidance to build judgment, not a guarantee of profit. Always verify current sold prices before you buy, and start small while you learn a category.